

Phishing Awareness Game

Game Design Document

The Cyber Safety Topic: Phishing Awareness in a University Context

MANISH THAPA

Everyday Dilemma

A choose-your-own-adventure web game that puts Coventry University students in real-life phishing situations — and shows the consequences of every click.

Phishing attacks are among the most common cyber threats targeting university students. This game focuses on three everyday attack vectors:

1. Suspicious Emails

Fake lecturer or IT messages designed to steal credentials.

2. Malicious Links

Shortened or disguised URLs hiding dangerous destinations.

3. Smishing Texts

Fake bank or security alerts sent via SMS.

Who We're Designing For

Coventry University students aged 18–25 are prime phishing targets — and they often don't realize it.

- **Always Connected:** Students check emails and texts quickly between lectures, often on mobile.
- **Financially Active:** Online banking, student loans, and part-time work make them high-value targets.
- **Platform Users:** Regular use of Moodle/Canvas and university IT systems creates multiple attack surfaces.

The Problem: "It Won't Happen to Me"

Busy students check messages quickly and assume they're too savvy to be fooled. But phishing attacks are designed to bypass that confidence.

One wrong click can mean stolen university login details, zero marks on an assignment, or real financial loss.

Common attacks include fake lecturer assignment requests, IT support password resets, and fake bank security alerts — all realistic enough to fool anyone.

Learning Objectives

What Players Will Take Away

By the end of the game, players should be able to:

- **Spot Red Flag #1:** Identify suspicious sender addresses that don't match the claimed organization.
- **Spot Red Flag #2:** Recognize urgent or threatening language designed to rush decisions.
- **Spot Red Flag #3:** Identify shortened, mismatched, or fake links before clicking.
- **Choose Safely:** Apply these skills to real university email, banking, and coursework scenarios.

Game Format

Choose-Your-Own-Adventure

The core loops follows a continuous sequence: **Read Scenario** → **Choose Action** → **Get Feedback** → **Next Scenario**.

Players step into the role of a 2nd-year Coventry University student during a busy semester. Every decision is final — just like in real life. Points are awarded after each choice, and the goal is to reach 80% + for the "Safe Semester" ending.

The Three Scenarios

Real Situations, Real Stakes

- **Scenario 1: Urgent Assignment Email**
A lecturer requests an urgent assignment re-upload via a suspicious link. Do you click?
- **Scenario 2: Fake IT Support**
An "IT Support" email demands an immediate password reset. The sender looks almost right.
- **Scenario 3: Bank Security Alert**
A text claims your bank account is frozen. A shortened link promises to restore access.

Feedback System

Instant Consequences, Instant Learning

No going back — just like real life. Every choice has a consequence.

✓ **Green Check (+25 pts):** Correct and safe. Well done.

⚠ **Yellow Warning (-5 pts):** Risky choice. You got away with it this time.

✗ **Red X (-15 pts):** Wrong. Here's what just happened to your data.

Every feedback screen includes three things:

- An explanation of the exact phishing red flags in that scenario
- A short, memorable learning tip to carry forward
- A realistic "what happened" consequence story showing real-world impact

Rewards & Endings

Three Possible Semesters

Your score determines how the semester ends. A visual "Semester Health" progress bar tracks performance throughout.

- 🏆 **Safe Semester — 80%+ :** You finish the semester successfully. Credentials intact, marks safe, bank account secure.
- 😬 **Stressful Semester — 50–79% :** Minor problems and stress. A few close calls, but you recover.
- 💣 **Failed Semester — Below 50% :** Realistic consequences: lost data, zero marks, or financial issues.

Measuring Success

How We Know It Works

The game is successful when players leave with genuine, lasting awareness — not just a high score.

- **Score 80% or above:** Achieving the "Safe Semester" ending demonstrates applied knowledge.
- **Name the three red flags:** Players can correctly identify suspicious senders, urgent language, and fake links.
- **Reflect on real life:** Post-game question: "What would you do differently next time in real life?"